

mortal form. Because of the Mists, changelings cannot draw upon the full knowledge of their fae selves, or their past-life memories of Arcadia and generations of immortal life. So much of the fae self is lost to hazy recollection or fragmented dreams thanks to the Mists' influence.

The Mists also wear down the changeling's connection to the Dreaming and keep them from naturally gathering Glamour from the world around them. Over time, a changeling runs out of Glamour unless she can find more from external sources. Eventually, she begins to lose touch with her own fae self. The changeling loses touch with not only her fae mien, but the memories of her fae lives, her memories stripped away by the *Forgetting*. The process of recapturing lost memories can seem like an impossible struggle against Banality itself, as the changeling is trapped within a nightmare of half-remembered visions and puzzling yearnings.

Should the changeling not receive the Glamour she needs to recover from her slide into *Forgetting*, she may be wholly subsumed by the Mists and Undone. This process speeds up should the changeling be harmed by anything that damages her fae mien, such as weapons like cold iron. Yet even those fae who have lost their way in the Mists may recover bits and pieces when the Mists part, and allow them a glimpse of their true selves. For changelings, that allows them tiny fragments of their past incarnations or even of Arcadia itself before the Mists lower again under the crushing weight of the world's Banality.

The Mists do offer one benefit to mortals by hiding the Dreaming and its children. The force of Banality in most mortals keeps them from perceiving anything outside of what they believe can exist. Should they spot anything that they cannot immediately explain, the Mists press them to rationalize it away as a temporary hallucination or trick of the mind. A mortal must be deliberately enchanted to pierce through the Mists to see the world of the Dreaming, lying hidden right before their eyes.

It's into those very Mists that all changelings might go, if — or when — they lose the battle with Banality.

How Changelings Age

Since a changeling's life span is tied directly to her mortal body, a changeling is born, goes through Chrysalis, and grows older and dies, only to be reborn and begin the process again. The cycle of death and rebirth assures that a fae soul may pass down through the generations, a shadow of the immortality that the fae once possessed. Yet during her lifetime, a fae ages from Chrysalis to the end of their lives based more on their exposure to Banality than mortal age.

Changelings emerge from the Chrysalis as *fledglings*, though their mortal forms may be already grown. A changeling's fae mien reflects that youth and vitality, as she has yet to truly feel the ravages of Banality's touch. Her apparent age or stage in life, known as her *seeming*, advances based upon her perception of the world and the way she resists the Banality all around her. Although most changelings pass through the three seemings linearly — childling to wilder to grump — seeming represents more than just the physical age of a changeling's mortal form.



Violent Ends and Cold Iron



To a changeling, the world is already a cold, Banal place, slowly sinking further away from the Dreaming. Yet with each changeling who is Undone, the world gets a little darker and a little more Banal. The act of taking a changeling life is an act of Banality, and changelings that slay one another are helping the Autumn world grow colder.

This goes even more so for any changeling that chooses to use a weapon made out of iron to harm a changeling or denizen of the Dreaming. Iron is deadly to changelings and an affront to the Dreaming itself. No one is sure entirely why, but legends hint that long ago, perhaps before the Sundering, the fae made a deal with iron itself. While the exact nature of the bargain is lost to time, it is said that iron became enraged when the fae did not uphold their part of the bargain. From that point on, iron became the eternal enemy of all fae, and when carried in the hands of an enemy, a changeling's deadliest foe. Most freeholds and parts of fae kingdoms make owning cold iron weapons illegal, and being caught with such a weapon is an open declaration of murderous intent.



It represents her outlook and approach to the Dreaming, as well as reflecting how she processes Banality. It is even possible for a changeling to change seemings "out of order" with time, moving from grump to childling or wilder and back again. None of this, however, does anything to prevent the changeling's physical body from aging. Indeed, all changelings know that they will more than likely be Undone before ever reaching a ripe old age.

Undoing reigns as the leading cause of death for changelings (along with violence at the hands of enemies). The loss of even one fae life is a horrible blow, as it marks another win for the Autumn world against magic, the fae, and the Dreaming itself. The fae soul that is Undone lies resting inside the mortal body it once inhabited, waiting for that mortal shell to die. Only then can the fae soul reincarnate into a different form to return to the mortal world. Yet that Undoing is not the worst fate that can befall a changeling.

Few fae fear the specter of death like the *sidhe*. Though some *sidhe* did take on the Changeling way and began the stages of being reborn on earth like the other Kithain, Arcadian *sidhe* have maintained their traditions of being untainted by the death-rebirth cycle of mortals. Instead, by choosing to steal mortal bodies, the Arcadians have left their future after death uncertain. No one is sure if Arcadian *sidhe* reincarnate, and those who have chosen to eschew the Changeling Way are frightened by the mystery of death that now stalks the once-eternal *sidhe*. House Liam presented the scandalous notion that nobles are indeed reborn, but as commoners, but that idea was shouted down or wholly ignored by most nobility. Still, Autumn *sidhe*